its rider – lose courage and escape at a gallop. On foot, the soldiers had no choice but to meet their fate. In Gujarat, too, the Kachhwaha Rajputs, Akbar's in-laws, had distinguished themselves: at least three of them fought in the absurdly perilous battle of Sarnal, and one of them died in it.

It may have been a Kachhwaha who began to tell the party of a Rajput custom by which two men would run at a *barchha*, a spear with two prongs, so that the blades 'would transfix them and come out at their backs'. Abul Fazl doesn't explain why two men would choose to disembowel themselves in this way – if, as one translation suggests, it was to resolve disputes, it was both drastic and pointless – and Akbar didn't care to ask. Instead, he leapt to his feet, put the 'hilt of his sword against a wall and held the other end near his regal belly'.[35]

A hush fell upon the party – what was Akbar doing? Was it that veil of his again, wonders Abul Fazl, hiding his true intentions; or was he 'weary of . . . worldly success'?[36] Was he, as other, less devoted historians have speculated over time, drunk out of his mind?

No one dared move as Akbar declared he could match any Rajput for suicidal bravado; no one 'had the power to utter a word, nor even to offer any opposition'.[37] No one, that is, except Man Singh. The prince of Amber, nephew of Harkha Bai, was in his early twenties, with nothing of the impressive girth he acquired with age and affluence. A lithe and dark young man, he knocked the sword from Akbar's hand; it cut a bit of the loose skin between the emperor's thumb and forefinger. Furiously, Akbar turned upon Man Singh, pushing him to the ground and falling upon him, his hands tightening around the prince's throat.

The hush was broken: in a painting of the scene, every man is on his feet, gesticulating wildly.[38] One of them, Sayyid Muzaffar, managed to stop Akbar, 'twisting his wounded finger' to make him release Man Singh.[39]

What is one to make of it, such seemingly demented behaviour in the story of a man famed through history for his intelligence and rationality? It wasn't, by any means, a drunken embarrassment to be hidden from the world – Abul Fazl recounts it in detail; it was painted for Akbar's biography. Perhaps its meaning was only what the words and image declare so transparently: there was no challenge Akbar wouldn't meet, and God save the man who tried to stop him.